

Career Research & Learning Plan: Business Analyst

1. Target Role

Role: Business Analyst (IT & Software Development Focus)

2. Research the Market

Based on current market trends (SEEK, LinkedIn Jobs, Indeed) and industry standards for IT/Software Business Analysts:

Key Responsibilities

- **Requirements Elicitation & Management:** Conduct structured elicitation (workshops, interviews, observation) to gather, analyze, and define end-to-end business, functional, and data requirements across enterprise portfolios (Finance, HR, Risk, Procurement, Legal).
- **Documentation & Artifact Creation:** Produce comprehensive business analysis deliverables, including Business Requirement Documents (BRDs), Functional Specifications, User Stories with Given-When-Then acceptance criteria, business cases, project briefs, RFPs, and decision logs.
- **Process Modeling & Optimization:** Map 'As-Is' and 'To-Be' business process workflows using standard notations (such as BPMN) to identify operational bottlenecks and improve controls.
- **Technical & Business Bridging:** Translate complex business needs into technical specifications and data requirements (data mappings, transformation logic, payload structures, and integration definitions) for architecture and development teams.
- **Agile Delivery & Backlog Refinement:** Participate in Agile/SAFe ceremonies (PI Planning, sprint refinement) to refine product backlogs, ensure stories meet the Definition of Ready, and maintain living documentation in Confluence/JIRA.
- **Testing & Implementation Support:** Define test scenarios, coordinate User Acceptance Testing (UAT), support change management, and facilitate smooth transition into business-as-usual (BAU) operations.
- **AI & Innovation Championing:** Promote the practical and responsible adoption of AI tools within division workflows to enhance decision-making and productivity.

Required Skills

- **Requirements & Process Analysis:** Advanced capability in elicitation, critical thinking, root-cause analysis, and process flow mapping.
- **Stakeholder Engagement & Influencing:** Proven ability to build trusted relationships, facilitate cross-functional workshops, extract consensus from disagreement, and manage expectations across both operational and senior leadership levels.
- **Technical & Data Literacy:** Strong conceptual understanding of system integrations, APIs, data structures, security protocols, and data mapping.
- **Agile & Project Frameworks:** Solid experience working within Agile, Scrum, or SAFe environments, managing backlogs, dependencies, and risks.
- **Domain & Regulatory Awareness:** Ability to navigate complex domain environments (e.g., Financial Services, ESG/Mandatory Disclosures, Insurance, Shared Services, or Healthcare) and build compliance requirements directly into solution designs.
- **Problem-Solving & Adaptability:** Ability to bring structure to ambiguous situations and turn strategic ideas into clear, actionable plans.

Tools and Technologies

- **Agile & Collaboration Platforms:** JIRA, Confluence.

- **Process Mapping & Diagramming:** BPMN tools, Visio, Lucidchart (for process maps, data flows, use cases, sequence diagrams).
- **Enterprise Systems & Platforms:** Enterprise ERPs (e.g., SAP / SAP HANA), Telephony/Collections platforms, Client Management Systems.
- **Data & Analytics Tools:** SQL (for querying, data analysis, and sourcing), Data Dictionaries, Data Transformation & Reporting tools.
- **Productivity & AI Tools:** Microsoft Office Suite, Microsoft Copilot, ChatGPT, and generative AI tools for BA deliverables.

Certifications Commonly Requested

- **IIBA Certifications:**
 - CBAP® (Certified Business Analysis Professional)
 - CCBA® (Certification of Capability in Business Analysis)
 - ECBA™ (Entry Certificate in Business Analysis)
- **Agile & Framework Certifications:**
 - SAFe® Product Owner / Product Manager (POPM)
 - IIBA®-AAC (Agile Analysis Certification)
 - CSM (Certified ScrumMaster) or PSM I (Professional Scrum Master)
- **Domain / Specialized Accreditation:**
 - Formal Business Analysis Accreditation / Diplomas from recognized professional bodies.

3. Skills & Resources Table

Tool/Technology	Purpose	Learning Resource
JIRA & Confluence	Agile project management, issue tracking, and documentation.	Atlassian University, LinkedIn Learning ("Jira Basic Training")
Visio / Lucidchart	Creating process flowcharts and system diagrams.	Microsoft Learn, YouTube tutorials
SQL (SQL Server)	Data querying, extraction, and basic data analysis.	LinkedIn Learning ("SQL Essential Training", "Learning SQL Programming")
Power BI	Data visualization and business intelligence reporting.	Microsoft Learn, LinkedIn Learning ("Power BI Essential Training")
Excel	Data manipulation, pivot tables, and basic modeling.	LinkedIn Learning, Coursera

4. 3–Week Learning Plan

Focus: Breadth over depth. Gain a basic understanding of each tool to effectively bridge the gap between business and IT.

- **Week 1: BA Fundamentals & Essential Tools (Jira)**

- *Goal:* Understand core business analysis responsibilities and get hands-on with Agile project management tools.
- *Tasks:* Complete the "Introduction to Business Analysis" and "Essential Tools and Techniques" courses. Watch the "Jira Tutorial for Beginners." For practice, set up a free Jira workspace for a mock software project (such as a mobile app for monitoring the wellbeing of agricultural biosecurity staff). Create a main Epic (e.g., "User Daily Check-in") and write 3-5 clear User Stories with acceptance criteria to populate your sprint board.
- **Week 2: Requirements, Process Modeling & Agile (Lucidchart)**
 - *Goal:* Learn to extract requirements from stakeholders and visually map out business processes within an Agile framework.
 - *Tasks:* Complete the "Requirements Elicitation" and "Agile Business Analysis" courses. Watch the "Business Process Modeling" course and the "Lucidchart Tutorial". For practice, log into Lucidchart and draw a "To-Be" process flowchart mapping out a specific user journey (e.g., a staff member opening the app, submitting a health report, and the system flagging an alert for a supervisor).
- **Week 3: Data Analytics & AI Integration (SQL, Power BI, ChatGPT)**
 - *Goal:* Develop technical data literacy to support stakeholder decisions and leverage AI to speed up daily workflows.
 - *Tasks:* Complete "Data Analysis: Investigate with SQL" and practice writing basic SELECT, WHERE, and JOIN queries using an online SQL simulator. Watch "Getting Started with Power BI" and practice by importing a mock Excel dataset to create a simple interactive dashboard (e.g., a bar chart and a KPI card). Finally, take "Learning ChatGPT for Business Analysis" and practice prompting the AI to refine and improve the User Stories you drafted in Week 1.

5. Tool Notes

Tool / Technology	What it is	Why it is used	Common use cases	Example
JIRA	An Agile project management and issue-tracking software.	To plan, track, and manage software development workflows and team tasks efficiently.	Managing sprint backlogs, tracking bug fixes, and managing Agile user stories.	A Business Analyst creates a user story ticket for a new system feature, assigns it to a developer, and tracks its progress from "To Do" to "In Progress" to "Done" on the Kanban board.
Confluence	A collaborative team workspace and centralized documentation wiki.	To create, share, and organize project documents so teams have a	Drafting Business Requirement Documents (BRDs), decision	The BA drafts a comprehensive functional specification document on a shared page, tagging

		single source of truth.	logs, and meeting notes.	developers and stakeholders to review the requirements synchronously and leave contextual comments.
Visio / Lucidchart	Visual workspace and diagramming applications for process mapping.	To create clear, visual representations of complex business processes or system architectures.	Drawing BPMN flowcharts, UML diagrams, and 'As-Is'/'To-Be' process maps.	The BA maps out the step-by-step customer onboarding journey using standard flowchart shapes, making it easy for stakeholders to visually identify current operational bottlenecks and approve the proposed 'To-Be' workflow.
SQL	A standard programming language for relational database management.	To securely query, extract, and manipulate large volumes of data directly from databases.	Data extraction, root-cause analysis, and validating data during system integrations.	To support a reporting request, the BA writes a SELECT query utilizing JOIN clauses to combine customer demographic data with their transaction history, extracting a clean dataset for further analysis.
Power BI	A business intelligence and data visualization platform by Microsoft.	To convert raw data from various sources into interactive, visually immersive dashboards.	Executive reporting, tracking key performance indicators (KPIs), and visual data	Connecting directly to an SQL database, the BA builds a dynamic dashboard featuring pie charts and trend lines that automatically

			analysis.	updates daily, allowing senior management to visually track project performance.
Excel	A spreadsheet program used for data recording, analysis, and visualization.	For rapid data manipulation, quick calculations, and basic modeling without complex coding.	Cleaning datasets, creating Pivot Tables, and performing basic data transformation.	Before importing data into a BI tool, the BA uses Excel's VLOOKUP to merge two separate data exports, cleans up missing values, and creates a quick Pivot Table to summarize regional sales totals.
ChatGPT / MS Copilot	Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) conversational assistants.	To augment productivity by rapidly generating text, summarizing information, and brainstorming.	Drafting initial user stories, summarizing interview notes, and generating test cases.	The BA inputs a rough transcript from a stakeholder requirement workshop into the AI, prompting it to generate a structured list of technical acceptance criteria, saving hours of manual drafting time.